



HEIR APPARENT: Bilawal poses at Christ Church College, Oxford

ment take responsibility for Benazir's untimely death and is firm that the current probe into her killing is farcical. He charges the government with rigging the upcoming polls but prefers that PPP stays in the fray. And he deftly avoids questions about impeaching Musharraf if his party comes to power, saying, "We will cross that bridge when we come to it." He was at pains to stress PPP's vision of a united Pakistani federation and also to "stop Pakistan from becoming a Taliban state". Asked about reports that he was contemplating shifting base from Sindh to Lahore, Punjab's provincial capital, he replied he would live in every part of Pakistan "because PPP represents all of Pakistan".

Leaders across the spectrum acknowledge Zardari's ascendancy in the political calculus. Retired Lt-General Moinuddin Haider, who was a Federal interior minister in Musharraf's Government, says, "Zardari is now the most powerful man in his party." Sharif, who had a long political discussion with him at Naudero

POLITICS IS ALSO IN MY BLOOD.

BILAWAL BHUTTO ZARDARI
PPP CHAIRMAN

nated veteran PPP leader Amin Fahim as the party's probable prime ministerial candidate. Zardari is aware of the resentment towards him within the party's rank and file—many had predicted that the party would splinter if he were to take over Bhutto's position—and his public posturing has placated most within the party, which is desperate for stability after the trauma of her death. At his first press conference after his wife's assassination, he demonstrated political maturity by not fanning the flames of emotional provincialism that had flared up in Sindh against Punjab. Zardari showed no trace of bitterness when he met Sharif, who had had him jailed soon after he took over as prime minister in 1996. Farhatullah Babar, PPP's chief spokesperson, says, "He has strung back the beads that had broken off from the political chain and were scattered after Bhutto's assassination."

Deep inside the Naudero household, away from the thronging crowds, Zardari spoke with a quiet determination to INDIA TODAY about his approach and vision for the future of Pakistan. Wearing a flowing black kurta, his hair combed firmly back, he made an effort not to sound confrontationist, saying, "We cannot afford bitterness in politics. PPP has never held that energy as useful. We don't hold anything against anybody. Our late leader Mohtarma Benazir Bhutto is known to have worked with all adversaries and managed to overcome all odds in difficult circumstances, so we have never taken things personally (*see interview*)."

Would that apply to working with President Pervez Musharraf as well? Zardari is sombre and cautious when he speaks of Pakistan's strongman, aware that anything he says would reverberate across the country. He does believe that Musharraf's govern-

soon after Bhutto's assassination, said he found him "reasonable" and "totally aware of everything that was going on in the party and the country". While Sharif had had Zardari arrested during his tenure as prime minister, his party-men never fail to remind PPP that during Bhutto's second term as prime minister, she had arrested Sharif's elderly father. Now Sharif claims that they both agreed to "sink the past and forget the bitterness". He declares: "I can do business with Mr Zardari. We will work together and move together to restore democracy and the rule of law."

The Government has watched the rapprochement between the two major parties, Bhutto's PPP and Sharif's Pakistan Muslim League (Nawaz) (PML-N) with growing consternation. The King's Party, the ruling PML(Q), has stepped up its criticism of the newfound unity. Pervez Elahi, former PML(Q) chief minister of Punjab, turned vituperative